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The Volcano’s Rim

Late in *Interstellar*, Cooper has just dragged the *Endurance* out of its death spiral at Mann’s planet and feels a great sense of relief when the robot Case says to him: “We’re heading into Gargantua’s pull.”

Cooper makes a quick decision: “The navigation mainframe’s destroyed and we don’t have enough life support to make it back to Earth. But we might scrape to Edmunds’ planet.” “What about fuel?” Amelia Brand asks. “Not enough,” Cooper responds. “Let Gargantua suck us right to [near] the horizon, then a powered slingshot around to launch us at Edmunds’ planet.” “Manually?” “That’s what I’m here for. I’ll take us just inside the critical orbit.”

Within minutes they are at the critical orbit and all hell breaks loose.

In this chapter, I describe my scientist’s interpretation of this.